Step 1: In the VirtualBox console, press the *New* icon and fill in the information, as shown in Figure 1, in the *Name* and *Operating system* window before pressing *Next*.

Note: In the above window, the *Windows 8.1 (64-bit)* option has been selected. 64-bit options will appear only if the host system has a 64-bit processor and it supports virtualisation technology. By default, most systems have the virtualisation support option disabled, so you'll need to enable it in the BIOS.

Note: If you are using the 32-bit image of Windows 8.1, select the Windows 8.1 (32-bit) option from the Version drop-down list.

Step 2: By default, VirtualBox assigns 2048 MB of RAM to a Windows 8.1 virtual machine. You can increase it to any amount as long as the pointer lies in the green area (as shown in Figure 2). Press *Next*, once done.

Note: 2048 MB of RAM is recommended only if you're not planning to run any memory intensive applications (e.g., Microsoft Office, an antivirus, etc) on the VM. If you wish to use this VM as an alternate PC, you may want to increase the RAM to a more suitable amount.

Steps 3 - 5: In the next three windows, select the following options:

- Hard drive: *Create a virtual hard drive now*
- Hard drive file type: *VDI (VirtualBox Disk Image)*
- Storage on physical hard drive: *Dynamically allocated*

Step 6: Specify the location and size of the virtual hard drive. Though 25 GB, available by default, will be sufficient for the purposes of this article, you can set it to any amount, depending on the free storage capacity available on the host system. Once done, press *Create*.

Step 7: Before switching on the VM, we'll need to point it to the *Windows 8.1 Enterprise* (90-day evaluation) image file to install the operating system. To do this select *Windows 8.1* and press the *Settings* icon in the top menu. Select *Storage* and then select *Empty* under the *Controller: IDE* section. Press the disk icon in the *Attributes* section, and select the *Choose a virtual CD/DVD disk file* option. Navigate to the location of the image file, select it and press *Open*. Press *OK* to close the *Settings* window.

Step 8: Press *Start* in the top menu and proceed with the Windows 8.1 installation.

Note: Post installation, select *Use Express Settings* on the *Settings* page.

Step 9: The last step in this section is to install *VirtualBox Guest Additions* on the virtual machine. To do this, select the *Insert Guest Additions CD Image* option from the *Devices* menu in the *Virtual Machine* window. Open *This PC* on the VM, double click on *VirtualBox Guest Additions CD Drive* and proceed with the installation. Reboot the VM when the installation is finished.

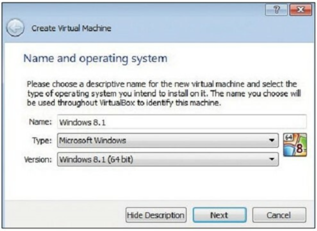

Figure 1: Name and operating system window

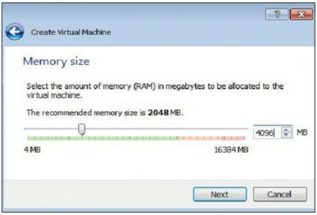

Figure 2: Allocate memory size

Setting up shared folders

Once the virtual machine is ready, we'll need to set up a shared folder between the host system and the VM. This folder will be used to place the files you want to access remotely.

To set up a shared folder, follow these instructions. In the VirtualBox console, select *Windows 8.1*. Click on the *Settings* icon and select *Shared Folders*. Press the + icon to add a folder and specify the desired folder path. Specify the folder name, as it should appear in the VM (without spaces). Uncheck *Read-only*. Check *Auto-mount*, press *OK* and close the *Settings* window.

Start the VM and open *This PC*. The shared folder should appear as a drive, as shown in Figure 6.

Accessing the shared folder remotely

Now that our backend setup is in place, let's work to make it remotely accessible. We'll do this with the help of Teamviewer, which is a must-have remote desktop sharing tool. In addition to its core functionality, it provides features like remote file sharing, virtual meetings, etc. Also, since it